

5. Sensory Responses & Outputs (How the Child Responds)

Objective language for describing how a child responds to sensory experiences.

These terms describe what you observe — not what it means. A child's response to sensory input can range from seeking more to actively avoiding. Document the specific response, its duration, and what helped. Never use 'sensory issues' or 'sensory problems' as a documentation term.

Reminder: Write 'During art time, Marcus pulled his hands away from the paint and said "yucky" four times' — not 'Marcus has sensory issues.' Your role is to describe what you observe.

Sensory Seeking Responses — The Child Appears to Want More Input

sought additional touch by rubbing materials on skin	requested to repeat the movement activity	chose to return to the sensory bin repeatedly
touched surfaces and materials frequently	put objects in mouth beyond typical age expectation	sought deep pressure by pressing against furniture or adults
jumped, spun, or rocked repeatedly during free choice	made loud sounds repeatedly in quiet settings	sought bright or moving visual stimulation
ran rather than walked in most contexts	frequently bumped into or leaned on peers	requested rough-and-tumble play
smelled objects before using or eating them		

Sensory Avoidance Responses — The Child Appears to Want Less Input

pulled hands away from material	covered ears with hands	turned head away from sound source
moved to the edge of the group	covered eyes	left the area when sound increased
pushed food away without tasting	gagged when near certain food textures	resisted transitioning between floor surfaces
removed clothing items (shoes, socks, tags)	avoided physical contact with peers	protested when touched unexpectedly
cried or became distressed when ____	closed mouth tightly when offered food	refused messy materials during art time
sat away from the group during sensory activities		

Neutral or Adaptive Responses – The Child Manages the Input Well		
engaged with the material for ____ minutes	participated with verbal encouragement	tolerated the input with adult proximity
requested a modification (e.g., gloves, tool)	returned to the activity after a short break	used a preferred tool to engage with material
self-selected a quieter area	asked for earmuffs/headphones during loud activity	used a visual schedule to prepare for sensory activity
calmed within ____ minutes after sensory experience	participated with a peer model present	

Physical Responses to Note (Describe, Do Not Diagnose)		
blinked repeatedly when ____	wrinkled nose when near ____	tensed shoulders when ____
stiffened body when touched	relaxed body when given deep pressure	became more alert after movement
became calmer after heavy work activity	yawned or appeared drowsy during ____	increased activity level after prolonged sitting
decreased activity level after movement break		